

When Engagement Failed as a Proxy for Progress

Lessons from a 25-person manual behavior experiment

Over the years I've worked on products where success depended on helping people achieve outcomes over long periods. One question kept bothering me:

Can a simple behavioral intervention meaningfully improve someone's day-to-day experience?

To find out, I ran a manual experiment with 25 participants around sleep and morning state. Every evening, a small anchor cue is sent via WhatsApp. Every morning, a check-in on how they woke up.

The setup

Responses were simple: whether the cue was completed (Yes / No / Tried) and how they woke up (Fresh / Okay / Low). That's it.

The assumption: better adherence → better mornings.

The reality was messier.

What I observed

Completion didn't guarantee improvement

One participant completed the cue consistently and still reported "Yes, low" for multiple consecutive days. The behavior changed. The outcome didn't follow.

Engagement didn't predict outcomes

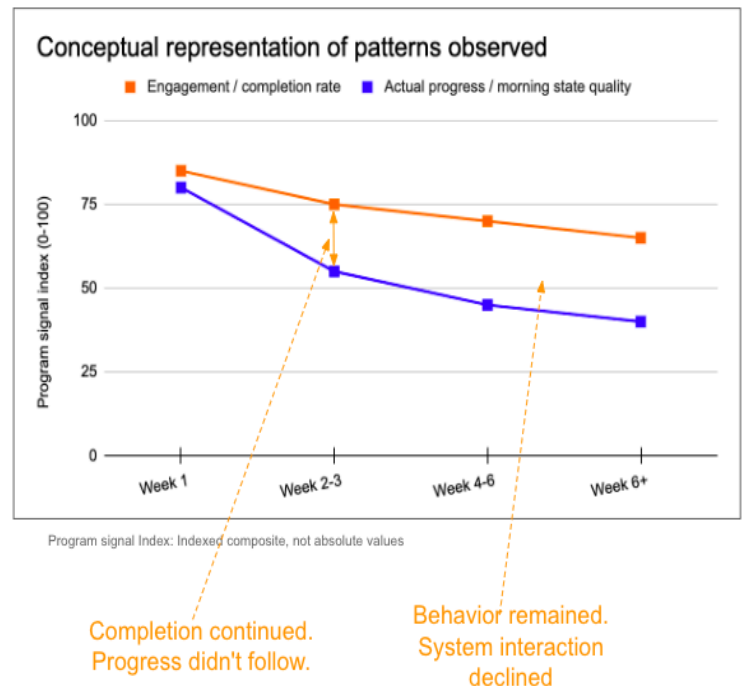
Engagement and outcomes moved independently. The correlation I assumed would be obvious simply wasn't there.

Silence wasn't disengagement

Some participants interacted less while still benefiting. One later said:

"Even if I miss your message now, I still remember following it myself."

The reminder had disappeared. The behavior remained.



What I built from this

This became the foundation for Rhythm Engine, a behavioral continuity logic engine that adapts demands based on user state rather than pushing for ideal behavior.

The question that stayed with me

If engagement, completion and outcomes can all move independently, what are we actually measuring when we say a user is doing well?

This experiment and the Hidden Middle diagnostic are two views of the same insight, one at the individual level, one across cohorts. dasyam.space/hiddenmiddle